

from a prior relationship. If you're unmarried and childless, the state will divide your estate among your relatives as it sees fit.

If you're in your twenties, single, and don't own much, you may feel that a will is unnecessary. Still, you probably own things that don't have any great monetary value but do have sentimental value and that you'd like a particular person to have.

What to Include in Your Will

The first step in estate planning is getting a handle on what you own so you can decide whom to leave it to. If you've followed earlier advice, you've already prepared a net worth statement and have a good idea of the value of your assets and belongings. To this list, add those items that have meaning to you but may not have a significant monetary value, such as family photo albums, personal journals, book or record collections, and pets.

Decide how you want your assets distributed if you die. For your primary beneficiaries, use percentages, not fixed dollar amounts, so that your will remains up-to-date as your assets increase or decrease. You can use fixed dollar amounts for secondary beneficiaries, for instance, if you want to leave money to a niece or nephew whom you dote on. However, you must always remember never to leave any property directly to a minor child. A trust will need to be set up so that a caretaker (called a trustee) can manage the assets for the children, make distributions for the children's benefit, and take care of trust administration.

Issues that you might want to address in your will include:

- Whether you want equal or unequal shares to go to your heirs
- What age you want your kids to be when they inherit
- How you want to distribute property that can't be divided without being liquidated or sold, such as a house
- What special arrangements you want made for kids from a previous marriage
- Whether you should make special provisions for one of your heirs who doesn't handle money wisely
- What arrangements you want made for a special-needs child who requires special care